

Saturday, 11 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Mostly clear 30° 19°	BIRMINGHAM Clear 30° 19°	MANCHESTER Clear 29° 20°	GLASGOW Light drizzle 22° 16°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

The British Army is set to embrace 'modern warfare' with a massive two-billion-pound investment in AI training.

This significant funding will create 270 new jobs in Wiltshire and support over 400 more across the UK. It's all part of preparing our forces for the future of conflict.

DEFENCE · UK
- 2

Reform UK is reportedly under investigation by the Metropolitan Police over election donations.

The Times newspaper claims the probe is focusing on donations made to the party by the mother of a convicted fraudster. It's a story that's making waves in Westminster.

POLITICS · UK
- 3

A government review into disability benefits is considering alternatives to traditional cash payments.

A minister has indicated the review is exploring whether some claimants could be directed towards other forms of support. It's a move that could significantly change how benefits are delivered.

SOCIAL POLICY · UK
- 4

Anglian Water has announced a hosepipe ban for the UK's driest region, due to 'unrelenting' hot and dry conditions.

This temporary measure comes as parts of the country continue to experience exceptionally low rainfall. Residents in the affected areas will need to conserve water.

ENVIRONMENT · UK
- 5

Ofcom is proposing new rules that would force big tech companies to tackle scam adverts on their platforms.

The communications regulator says more than half of UK adults have encountered potentially fraudulent ads online. The move aims to better protect consumers from digital scams.

TECHNOLOGY · UK

What's coming up

1

Oscar-winning actor Sir Anthony Hopkins is set to release his debut album, inspired by his childhood.

The collection features pieces the legendary actor has been working on for over six decades. It's a fascinating new creative venture from a true Hollywood icon.

ON AIR – What do you think Sir Anthony Hopkins' music will sound like? Do you think more actors should release albums?

MUSIC · COMING UP

2

Melanie C has described the Spice Girls' 30th anniversary as an 'emotional' moment.

Sporty Spice reflected on the band's enduring legacy as she accepted a global impact award in London. It's clear the bond between the Spice Girls remains strong.

ON AIR – Can you believe it's been 30 years since the Spice Girls burst onto the scene? What's your favourite Spice Girls memory?

MUSIC · ANNIVERSARY

3

Love Island winner Cach Mercer is the latest star to join the line-up for this year's Strictly Come Dancing.

The popular reality TV personality, model, and DJ will be swapping the villa for the ballroom. Fans are already excited to see her dance moves.

ON AIR – Are you excited to see Cach Mercer on Strictly? Which Love Island star would you love to see on the show?

TV · COMING UP

4

Duchess Sophie has made a special cameo appearance in the much-loved BBC Radio 4 drama, The Archers.

The Duchess of Edinburgh travelled to Birmingham to record her scenes with the Ambridge regulars. Her episode is set to air on Thursday.

ON AIR – What do you think Duchess Sophie's character will be like in The Archers? What other famous faces would you like to hear in Ambridge?

RADIO · COMING UP

5

Pontypridd, Birkenhead, and the Isle of Bute are among the 15 locations shortlisted for the first-ever UK Town of Culture award.

Other towns like Basildon, Grimsby, and Rotherham also made the cut in this exciting new initiative. It's a chance for these communities to showcase their unique cultural identities.

ON AIR – Which town do you think deserves to be the first UK Town of Culture? What makes your hometown special?

CULTURE · COMING UP

On the schedule

1 **British wildcard Arthur Fery has been beaten in straight sets by Alexander Zverev, who reaches his first Wimbledon final.**

Despite the loss, Fery's incredible run to the semi-finals has been the talk of the tournament. Andre Agassi has tipped him for 'one heck of a career'.

ON AIR – What an incredible run for Arthur Fery! Do you think he'll be a future Wimbledon champion?

TENNIS · UK

2 **England's preparations for their World Cup quarter-final against Norway have been hit by injury and illness.**

Defender Marc Guehi is a doubt with a hamstring injury, while Declan Rice has missed training due to a sickness bug. Gareth Southgate will be hoping they recover in time.

ON AIR – How much of a blow are these setbacks for England? Do you think they can still beat Norway without them?

FOOTBALL · UK

3 **Conor McGregor made a dramatic return to the UFC stage, ripping Max Holloway's glasses off in an intense face-off.**

The controversial fighter is back after a five-year absence, with their highly anticipated rematch at UFC 329 in Las Vegas on Saturday. Fans are buzzing for the fight.

ON AIR – Are you excited for Conor McGregor's return to the octagon? Do you think he can still dominate after such a long break?

MMA · WHEN

4 **World number one Scottie Scheffler has stunningly missed his first cut in four years at the Scottish Open.**

The golf superstar slumped to an early exit, marking a rare blip in his otherwise dominant form. It's a result that has surprised many in the golfing world.

ON AIR – Were you surprised to see Scottie Scheffler miss the cut? Does this open the door for someone else to win?

GOLF · UK

5 **France have cruised into the World Cup semi-finals after a comfortable win over Morocco.**

Kylian Mbappe scored his eighth goal of the tournament, with Ousmane Dembele adding a second. Many are now tipping France to go all the way and win the competition.

ON AIR – Are France unstoppable at this World Cup? Can anyone beat them now?

FOOTBALL · WORLD

Quick hits

- 1 A new trend sees people transforming old phone boxes into mini community libraries.**
These charming, repurposed red phone boxes are popping up in villages and towns, offering a free book exchange for locals. It's a wonderful way to give these iconic structures a new lease of life and encourage reading.
- 2 The comforting appeal of 'collecting vintage postcards' is seeing a gentle resurgence.**
People are rediscovering the joy of these small pieces of history, often revealing glimpses into past holidays and everyday life. It's a lovely, tactile hobby that connects us to bygone eras.
- 3 Many are discovering the soothing pastime of 'identifying wildflowers' during their daily walks.**
Armed with apps or guidebooks, enthusiasts are taking time to appreciate the natural beauty around them, turning a simple stroll into a botanical adventure. It's a great way to engage with nature on your doorstep.
- 4 A charming trend for 'decorating bird feeders' is turning them into miniature works of art.**
People are getting creative with paint, beads, and repurposed materials to make their feeders stand out. It adds a lovely splash of colour to the garden and makes our feathered friends feel even more welcome.
- 5 The humble 'button' is being celebrated as a surprisingly versatile item beyond fastening clothes.**
From craft projects and jewellery making to creating unique decorative displays, buttons are proving to be a treasure trove for creative minds. It's amazing what you can do with a collection of old buttons.
- 6 A recent study suggests that the simple act of 'humming a favourite tune' can actually improve concentration.**
Researchers found that a gentle hum helps to block out distractions and can even boost memory recall. So next time you're trying to focus, a little hum might be just the ticket!
- 7 A delightful trend for 'making homemade cordials' from garden produce is flourishing.**
Using everything from elderflowers to home-grown berries, people are crafting delicious, natural drinks. It's a tasty and satisfying way to enjoy the fruits of your labour, literally.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to fix a tricky bit of flat-pack furniture, even though we know it won't help?

ANSWER: TALKING TO IT, USUALLY WITH A STERN VOICE!

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'song' they absolutely have to listen to first thing on a Saturday morning to get them in a good mood. What's their go-to tune?

ANSWER: THEIR ABSOLUTE FAVOURITE UPBEAT CLASSIC, NO MATTER HOW OLD IT IS!

TALK TOPIC

- **Do you remember the first time you 'mastered a new recipe' and it felt like a real culinary triumph?**
Perhaps it was a tricky soufflé or a perfectly roasted joint. What was that dish, and did it become a regular in your kitchen?
- **We all have those 'little rituals' we do to make a trip to the supermarket a bit more organised, don't we?**
Perhaps it's a specific order you visit the aisles, or a particular way you load the trolley. What's your secret to a smooth supermarket sweep?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** Did you know that a group of owls is actually called a 'parliament'?

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** A 'shiver' of sharks is a commonly used collective noun for a group of these ocean predators.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£6.6 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£6.6 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- Honey never spoils; archaeologists have even found pots of honey in ancient Egyptian tombs that are still edible.
- The shortest war in history was between Britain and Zanzibar on August 27, 1896, lasting only 38 minutes.
- The Eiffel Tower can be 15 cm taller during the summer due to the thermal expansion of the iron.
- The 'king of fruits', the durian, is known for its strong odour but is considered a delicacy in Southeast Asia.
- More than half of the world's population has never made or received a phone call.
- The world's largest snowflake on record was 15 inches wide and 8 inches thick, reported in Montana in 1887.
- The British tradition of afternoon tea began in the mid-19th century thanks to the Duchess of Bedford.
- The 'penny farthing' bicycle was named for its two wheels, one much larger than the other, resembling the old British coins.

On this day

Day 192 of the year, 173 days left in 2026. Today Christian Feast Day: Benedict of Nursia; Christian Feast Day: Drostan; Christian Feast Day: Kjeld; Christian Feast Day: Marciana of Toledo. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1972 — Cormac Battle, English-Irish singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer
- 1953 — Peter Brown, American singer-songwriter and producer
- 1973 — Andrew Bird, American indie rock singer-songwriter and violinist
- 1964 — Craig Charles, English actor and TV presenter
- 1958 — Mark Lester, English actor
- 1952 — Stephen Lang, American actor and playwright
- 1966 — Ricky Warwick, Northern Irish musician
- 1943 — Tom Holland, American actor, director, and screenwriter

THE DAY TODAY

- 1950 — Pakistan joins the International Monetary Fund and the International Bank.
- 2021 — Virgin Galactic launches its founder, Richard Branson, into space, the first company ever to do so.
- 1972 — The first game of the World Chess Championship 1972 between challenger Bobby Fischer and defending champion Boris Spassky starts.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1995 — Yugoslav Wars: Srebrenica massacre begins, lasting until 22 July.
- 1983 — A TAME airline Boeing 737-200 crashes near Cuenca, Ecuador, killing all 119 passengers and crew on board.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1943 — Massacres of Poles in Volhynia and Eastern Galicia by the Ukrainian Insurgent Army within the Reichskommissariat Ukraine (Volhynia) peak.
- 1982 — Italy defeats West Germany 3–1 to win the FIFA World Cup.

1962 — Project Apollo: At a press conference, NASA announces lunar orbit rendezvous as the means to land astronauts on the Moon, and return them to Earth.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 193 of the year, 172 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Feast of Saints Peter and Paul (Eastern Orthodox); Christian feast day: Hermagoras and Fortunatus; Christian feast day: Jason of Thessalonica (Catholic Church); Christian feast day: John Gualbert. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1962 — Dan Murphy, American musician
- 1955 — Timothy Garton Ash, English historian and author
- 1942 — Swamp Dogg, American R&B singer-songwriter and musician
- 1992 — Luke Berry, English footballer
- 1964 — Gaby Roslin, English television host and actress
- 1959 — Charlie Murphy, American actor and comedian (died 2017)
- 1969 — Jesse Pintado, Mexican-American guitarist (died 2006)
- 1976 — Tracie Spencer, American singer-songwriter and actress

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1920 — The Soviet–Lithuanian Peace Treaty is signed, by which Soviet Russia recognizes the independence of Lithuania.
- 2013 — Six people are killed and 200 injured in a French passenger train derailment in Brétigny-sur-Orge.
- 1973 — A fire destroys the entire sixth floor of the National Personnel Records Center of the United States.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2024 — Gazpromavia Flight 9608 crashes in Russia's Kolomensky District near Kolomna, killing three.
- 2012 — A tank truck explosion kills more than 100 people in Okobie, Nigeria.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026	
FRI 17	Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey (+ IMAX); Cut Off
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)